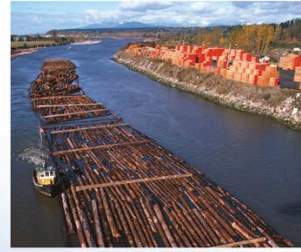




Western Canada and Alaska

CANADA IS A HUGE COUNTRY—its western half stretches from the flat prairies in the east to the towering Rocky Mountains in the west, and from the relatively mild south to the permanently frozen area north of the Arctic Circle. Harsh conditions over much of the region mean that most of the population is concentrated in cities in the south, such as Vancouver, Calgary, and Winnipeg. The Prairies—once a vast expanse of grassland—are now used mainly for growing wheat on huge mechanized farms. Oil and natural gas are found there as well. These natural resources are also important in Alaska, a part of the United States. The majority of Alaska's people moved there to work in these lucrative industries.



FORESTRY
Large parts of western Canada are covered in forests and lumbering is a major part of the local economy. The trees are used to make buildings, furniture, and paper. In the past, whole areas of trees were cleared but now sustainable methods, such as selective cutting and replanting, are practiced.

Felled trees transported down a river near Vancouver



TOTEM POLES
The native peoples of British Columbia use totem poles to record their clan history. Each carved and painted totem describes a real or mythical event and often features animals that the clan has a close connection with, such as the eagle (left).



DOGSLED RACING
The state sport of Alaska is dogsled racing. Here, competitors take part in the annual Iditarod Trail Sled Dog Race, a grueling run across the rugged landscape for drivers and their teams of dogs.

VANCOUVER
This city's vibrant cultural mix is typical of Canada's diversity. Many South Asian, Chinese, as well as other ethnic groups live here and reflect Vancouver's historic role as a destination for migrants. Hosting the 2010 Winter Olympics raised its profile and its bustling economy, mild climate, and cultural links make it an attractive place to live.

